



2026 Concert

Sunday September 20, 2:00pm
TSB Showplace, New Plymouth

Programme

Ludwig van Beethoven **Piano Concerto No. 5 – “Emperor”**

- I. Allegro
- II. Adagio un poco mosso
- III. Rondo: Allegro ma non troppo

Benjamin Booker – Piano

Interval

Richard Wagner

Prelude and Liebestod
from **Tristan und Isolde**

Richard Strauss

Tod und Verklärung

Ludwig van Beethoven (1770 – 1827)

Piano Concerto in E $\flat$ major No. 5 Op. 73 – “Emperor”

- I. Allegro
- II. Adagio un poco mosso
- III. Rondo: Allegro ma non troppo

Beethoven’s “emperor” concerto is now so firmly established in the repertoire that it is easy to forget just how radical it was at the time of composition. Innovation is present from the very first bar, where the concerto opens with a series of piano flourishes: a contrast to the traditional orchestral introduction seen in concerti by Mozart, Haydn, and in earlier concerti by Beethoven himself. The concerto thereafter is full of dramatic contrasts, between the virtuosity of the solo piano part, military orchestral tutti, a lyrical second movement, and the lively finale. That the concerto does not sound radical when performed today, speaks to the degree of influence that Beethoven would have over future generations of composers.

The origin of the subtitle “emperor” remains a mystery. It did not come from Beethoven itself. That it remains consistently used in the English-speaking world reflects the grandiosity and drama of this most beloved of concerti.

Richard Wagner (1813 – 1883)

Prelude and Liebestod from *Tristan und Isolde*

Tristan and Isolde, first premiered in 1865, represents not only one of the most influential operas in the repertoire, but one of the most influential concert works of the 19th century. The central premise of the opera is consumption of a magical love potion by both title characters. The resulting unmet desire is only resolved by the death of the lovers – and implied transfiguration thereafter.

Wagner was profoundly influenced by the philosophy of Arthur Schopenhauer, who promoted the concept of the “will to live”: an unsatiable desire said to pervade humanity. *Tristan and Isolde* thus reflects on primal unfulfilled wants, extending beyond the theme of love alone.

The Prelude and Liebestod (literally “love death”) comprise the opening and conclusion of the opera. Performed together, without break and without singer, they represent a staple of the concert repertoire – in fact performed in this format prior to the premiere of the opera proper. The prelude famously opens with a 4-note phrase that culminates in a dissonant chord. Dissonance was not in itself new, but Wagner radically does not resolve the dissonance until the very

end of the opera. Put another way, throughout the opera Wagner employs harmonic techniques that result in the music feeling always unsettled and not yet concluded; at least, not concluded until the deaths of Tristan and Isolde. We are therefore drawn in, sharing, in the most primal sense, the intense longing – and the eventual profound sense of fulfilment.

Richard Strauss (1864 – 1949)

Tod und Verklärung (Death and Transfiguration)

In naming one of his earliest tone poems *Death and Transfiguration*, Strauss explicitly associated the work with a programme, described further in his own words as telling the story of:

The dying hours of a man who had striven towards the highest idealist aims, maybe indeed those of an artist. The sick man lies in bed, asleep, with heavy irregular breathing; friendly dreams conjure a smile on the features of the deeply suffering man; he wakes up; he is once more racked with horrible agonies; his limbs shake with fever—as the attack passes and the pains leave off, his thoughts wander through his past life; his childhood passes before him, the time of his youth with its strivings and passions and then, as the pains already begin to return, there appears to him the fruit of his life's path, the conception, the ideal which he has sought to realize, to present artistically, but which he has not been able to complete, since it is not for man to be able to accomplish such things. The hour of death approaches, the soul leaves the body in order to find gloriously achieved in everlasting space those things which could not be fulfilled here below.

By reflecting on fulfillment following death, *Death and Transfiguration* clearly parallels themes in *Tristan and Isolde*: perhaps unsurprising given that Strauss was known to have studied the score for *Tristan and Isolde* in his teenager years. Much later in life, Strauss' song *Im Abendrot (At Sunset)* (composed at age 84), the last in his set of *Four Last Songs* and the last music he would compose, quoted the transfiguration theme from *Death and Transfiguration* (composed at age 23) as the singer asks “could this perhaps be death?”.

Programme notes by Tom Wilkinson.

Our Soloist

Benjamin Booker

Benjamin Booker has been inspired and disturbed by music ever since being given a glockenspiel for his first birthday. He began childhood piano lessons in Palmerston North, and, having departed from that metropolis for the time being, furthered his studies in Wellington at Victoria University, emerging a Bachelor of Music with first-class honours in 2012. He has played keyboard in New Zealand's National Youth Orchestra, concertised with the Manawatū and Whangārei Sinfonias, and received the Original Interpretations prize at Jakarta's Indonesia Pusaka piano competition.

Medical work since then has swept him from the Tai Tokerau to Canterbury to Uganda, and presently he works as a rural generalist in the West Coast, where he divides his time between hospital work and unjamming Te Whatu Ora's perpetually dysfunctional printers. This performance marks his return to the stage since an ill-fated African motorbike ride left him with a pair of broken wrists: a life experience he cannot recommend with any enthusiasm.

He would like to acknowledge his teachers Guy Donaldson, Richard Mapp, and Jian Liu, as well as Rosa Leggat and the Christchurch hand therapy team.

Our Conductor

José Aparicio

José began studying music with his father at the age of five, continuing his flute studies at Alicante's Music Conservatoire where he graduated in 1995 having won the graduation competition and the Sociedad de Conciertos de Alicante Prize. He then played as a soloist with orchestras for a year and in 1996 became principal flute of the Orquesta Sinfónica de Alicante and Orquesta de Camara Ciudad de Elche, touring with them both extensively.

In 1998 he moved to London to study postgraduate flute, conducting and singing at the Guildhall School of Music and Drama where he graduated in 2004, and won the adjudicator price in the prestigious Gold Medal competition.

Here in New Zealand, José is the Artistic Director of Napier Civic Choir, Festival Opera, National Youth Opera Aotearoa and Project Prima Volta as well as Principal Conductor of the Hawke's Bay Orchestra. José made his debut with the New Zealand Symphony Orchestra in 2023.

This is José's fourth time conducting the New Zealand Doctors Orchestra.

About the Orchestra

This is the 14th year that the New Zealand Doctors Orchestra has met. Previous performances have been in Nelson, New Plymouth, Napier, Christchurch, and Dunedin.

The members of the orchestra are doctors or medical students, with 11 guest players. All members maintain a strong part-time interest in music, with many having very impressive musical CVs.

Each year we donate all proceeds from ticket sales. This year we are proud to donate all proceeds to **Hospice Taranaki**.

Acknowledgements

We are very grateful for sponsorship from MAS, and sponsorship from the University of Otago (Division of Humanities Performing Arts Fund and the Medical School), and the University of Auckland (Faculty of Medicine and Health Sciences) which has been used to subsidise costs for our student players.

We are also very grateful to Anne Bovett for her help arranging instruments to borrow and finding local guest players, and Hospice Taranaki for transporting instruments and equipment.

The 2026 New Zealand Doctors Orchestra

First Violins

Rachel Moxham^{rot}
Justine Bradley^{chc}
Julian Bauer^{akl}
Robert Torrance^{akl}
Matthew Farrant^{wre}
Anne Yu^{npl}
Roy Knill^{akl}
Meg Yen^{akl}
Angela Fang^{dun}
Celina Tsui^{akl}
Caitlyn O'Fallon^{wlg}
Emily Jin^{wlg}
Lorna Pairman^{chc}
Elaine Wong^{wlg}
Ellen Simpson^{chc}
Anna Casey^{wre}
Emily Joe^{ham}

Second Violins

Louise Webster^{akl}
Nick Pittar^{chc}
Thomas Winter^{akl}
Iain Ward^{chc}
Sally Langley^{chc}
Anne Eastwood^{dun}
Sean Ea^{wlg}
Erika Sirisomboonwong^{chc}
Sonja Sparrow^{qt}
Rosemary Bond^{rot}
Matilda Sellier^{nsn}
David Sinclair^{akl}
Hazel Whitcombe^{has}
Hannah Moore^{wlg}
Lynette Murdoch^{chc}
Eva Hochstein^{akl}

Violas

Anthony Doyle^{akl}
Alex Hurrell^{chc}
Wei Tian Teo^{akl}
Kaylene Murdoch^{*chc}
Fiona McPherson^{qt}
Tonya Sadler^{chc}
Susan Case^{*npl}
Faith Austin^{*arw}
Penny Christiansen^{*akl}

Cellos

Peter Fleischl^{tau}
Esther Wu^{akl}
Paul van Houtte^{wlg}
Wendy Ni^{inv}
Clare Woodward^{akl}
Dominic Monaghan^{wlg}
Katy Brett^{chc}
Mike Hurrell^{chc}
Paul Teoh^{akl}

Double Basses

Tim Wilkinson^{chc}
Gerald Oliver^{*chc}
Emma Mill^{*pn}
Andrew Tan^{*akl}

Flutes

Karin Lamb^{chc}
Malcolm Carmichael^{ham}
Tina Chou^{ham}
Kate Sinclair^{ham}

Oboes / Cor anglais

David Roberts^{wlg}
Rosie Melgrove^{chc}
Ruth Moore^{blh}

Clarinets

Gautam Pathumanithy^{akl}
Andrew Marshall^{wlg}
Sarah de Vries^{npl}

Bass Clarinet

Jonathan Christiansen^{akl}

Bassoons

Martin Gardner^{chc}
Rebecca Brimble-Rajay^{akl}
Betty Ji^{akl}
Matthew Payne^{dun}

Horns

Rhona Sommerville^{akl}
Hugh Goodman^{cam}
David Johnson^{pn}
James Smith^{syd}

Trumpets

Tom Wilkinson^{chc}
Kate Hall^{wlg}
Matt McCall^{dun}
Lucy Page-Dalton^{chc}

Trombones

Mark Barnes^{ham}
Max Wilkinson^{*nyc}

Bass trombone

Alan Ramage-Brown^{*npl}

Tuba

Dylan Blomquist^{wlg}

Percussion / Timpani

Anne Bovett^{*npl}
Tomas Verbeek^{*npl}

Harp

Vanessa Souter^{wlg}

Location key: ARW Arrowtown AKL Auckland BLH Blenheim CAM Cambridge CHC Christchurch DUN Dunedin HAM Hamilton HAS Hastings INV Invercargill NSN Nelson NPL New Plymouth NYC New York PN Palmerston North QT Queenstown ROT Rotorua SYD Sydney TAU Taupō WLG Wellington WRE Whangarei

* guest player

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